# 5.2 Quebec and the British Victory

The stakes were high in the French and Indian War. Ultimately, the outcome of the war would determine which countries controlled North America.

**MAIN IDEA** The British and French fought for control of North America in the French and Indian War, with extensive losses on both sides.

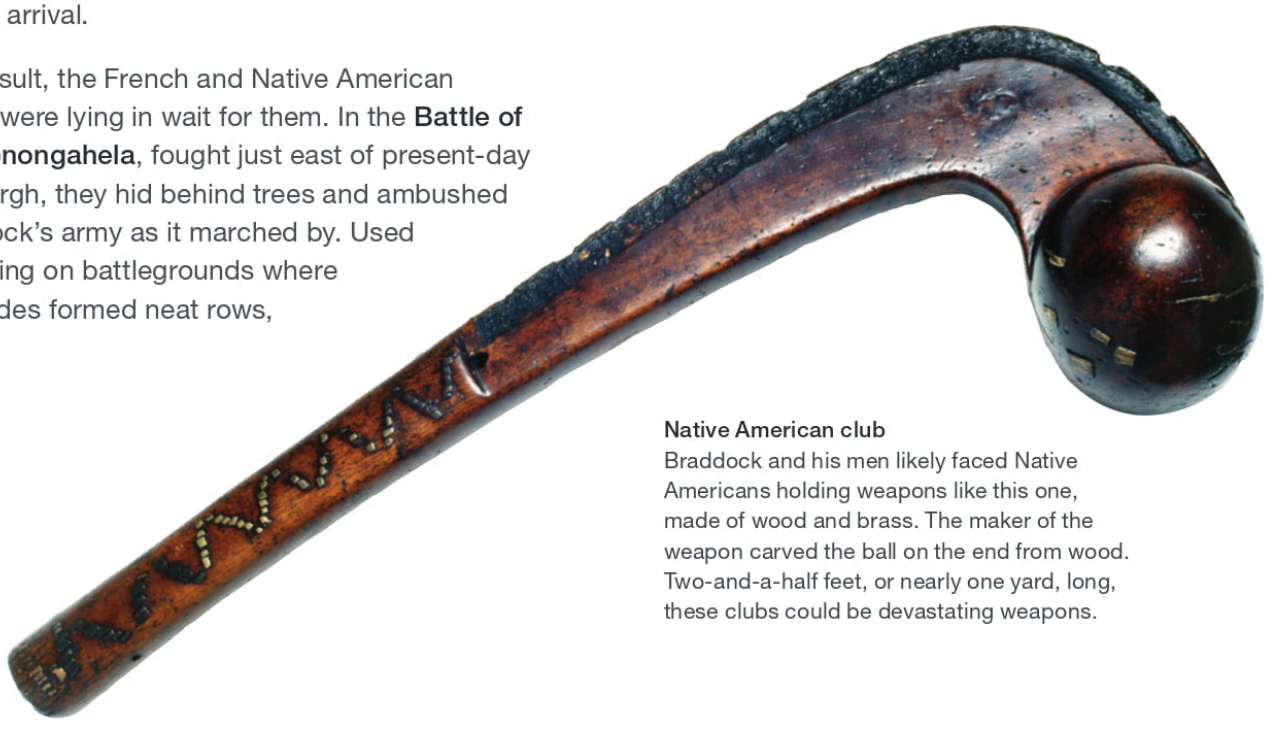
## EARLY BRITISH LOSSES

In response to the colonists' request for help, the British jumped into the fight. In 1755, they sent British general Edward Braddock and two regiments to North America to destroy French forts. George Washington accompanied Braddock as he marched with his more than 2,000 soldiers through the Virginia backcountry on a mission to capture Fort Duquesne. Braddock was confident that his highly trained soldiers would quickly defeat the enemy.

He was wrong. The British soldiers were totally unprepared for fighting on the frontier. Their wagons were too big for the paths, and they offended many of the Native American scouts they'd recruited to lead the way, causing most of them to abandon the soldiers. The army's slow progress gave the French plenty of notice of their clumsy arrival.

As a result, the French and Native American troops were lying in wait for them. In the **Battle of the Monongahela**, fought just east of present-day Pittsburgh, they hid behind trees and ambushed Braddock's army as it marched by. Used to fighting on battlegrounds where both sides formed neat rows, the British soldiers were caught completely off guard. Washington suggested they break ranks and fight from behind trees like the French, but Braddock refused. Within a few hours, nearly two-thirds of the British forces lay dead or wounded. Braddock himself soon died of his wounds. Washington, his uniform ripped by bullets, helped lead the retreat.

Losses continued to plague the British in the early years of the war. In New York, the French seized Fort William Henry, Fort Oswego, and 2,000 British soldiers at Lake George. The British defeats emboldened Native American tribes allied with the French to attack British settlements in the backcountry, where they killed and captured hundreds of settlers. Things looked bleak for the British and colonial forces.



**Native American club**
Braddock and his men likely faced Native Americans holding weapons like this one, made of wood and brass. The maker of the weapon carved the ball on the end from wood. Two-and-a-half feet, or nearly one yard, long, these clubs could be devastating weapons.



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**CRITICAL VIEWING** At the moment captured here in the Battle of the Monongahela, Washington is still on his horse and in command as the wounded General Braddock falls before him. Junius Brutus Stearns painted *Washington as a Captain in the French and Indian War* around 1851. In a time before photography, how did this painting effectively convey information about the battle?

## FRENCH DEFEATS

The tide turned after British statesman **Sir William Pitt** poured money and men into the war. In July 1758, the British captured Louisbourg in Nova Scotia (NOH-vuh SKOH-shuh). Alarmed, the French pulled their troops from the Ohio Valley so they could protect Quebec and Montreal. The retreat allowed the British to take control of the west. Cut off from French supplies and weakened by smallpox, Native Americans ended their war in the backcountry.

Even with extra troops, the French could not save Quebec. The British captured the city in 1759 during the **Battle of Quebec**. Encouraged by these victories, the Iroquois joined forces with Britain. In 1760, the British captured Montreal, ending French control of Canada.

The defeat of the French in Canada marked the end of the war with France in North America. A treaty would be signed, but the war had a lasting impact on everyone who had taken part in it. For one thing, thousands of colonists had joined the British army. They found that, at best, the British soldiers and officers looked down on them, and at worst, the British dealt out severe punishments to soldiers for small offenses. Colonial soldiers didn't feel they'd been treated like allies. The war would also cause great suffering to Native Americans. Soon settlers would invade even more of their homeland.

### HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Braddock's defeat at Fort Duquesne show that the British were not ready to fight a frontier war?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What turned the tide of the French and Indian War?
3. **DETERMINE CHRONOLOGY** What happened after Braddock and Washington marched to capture Fort Duquesne?



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